ADJUIS

Client Onboarding Packet

“I lead with listening. The ideas speak for themselves.”

WELCOME

Thank You for Choosing Adjuis

I truly appreciate your business, and I know you're excited to get your designs underway. Visuals, visuals, visuals, I get it. But the design process starts well before we open a single file for the logo, the mood boards, or the mock ups.

We begin by going through a set of detailed questions, so I can get a real sense of your company and its background. I want to understand why you started your company in the first place, what it stands for, and where you want it to go. If there is ever a detail the questionnaire misses that you feel matters, add it. That conversation is part of the process too.

From there, we'll talk through your likes and dislikes and build a blueprint for success, one that you define. Only once that blueprint is set do we move into visuals, as the final step.

I want you to feel involved in this process every step of the way.

Corey Manning
Founder, Adjuis

OUR PROCESS

How We Work Together

Good design isn't the first move, it's the last one. Before we touch a mood board or a logo sketch, we build the understanding that everything visual will stand on. Here is what that looks like.

Phase One: The Questionnaire

This is where we start, always. A detailed set of questions gets me inside your company: how it started, what it does, who it serves, and why it exists at all. I'm not just collecting facts for a brief, I want to understand the story behind the business. If something comes up along the way that the questionnaire didn't ask about, tell me. Some of the best insight shows up in the margins, not the answer boxes.

Phase Two: Your Blueprint for Success

With your background in hand, we shift to what you like, what you don't, and what success actually looks like to you. This isn't me guessing at your taste, it's a conversation. Together we build a blueprint, a shared, written definition of what we're aiming for, so that everything we design afterward has something real to answer to. You define success. My job is to help you put it into words we can both point back to.

Phase Three: Visual Exploration

Only now do we get to the part you've been waiting for: the logo, the mood boards, the mock ups. Because it comes last, every visual decision we make is already answering to something you told me, not a guess I made on your behalf. This is the payoff of the process, and it tends to move faster and land closer to right because of everything that came before it.

BEFORE WE BEGIN

A Brief History of Logos and Visual Identity

Before we start building yours, it helps for both of us to stand on the same ground. Here is a short look at where marks and visual identity came from, and how we got to where the practice stands today. I revisit this with every client relationship. There's always something to rediscover in it, no matter how many times I've walked through it before.

Marks Before Branding

Long before anyone called it branding, people were marking ownership and origin. Livestock brands, stonemason's marks, and medieval guild marks all did the same basic job: tell you who made this, or who this belongs to. These weren't designed for beauty, they were designed for recognition and trust, which is still the whole point of a mark today.

The Birth of the Trademark

The idea of legally protecting a mark took shape with industrialization, once goods started traveling further than the person who made them. Bass Brewery's red triangle, registered in England in 1876 under the country's new Trade Mark Registration Act, is widely credited as the first registered trademark, a symbol strong enough to stand in for a company's reputation on a shelf the owner would never personally stand behind. Around the same period, marks like Johnson & Johnson's script, established in the 1880s, and Mercedes-Benz's three pointed star in 1909, set a template that still echoes: simple, ownable, and built to last decades without a redesign.

The Modernist Era

The mid twentieth century is when visual identity became a discipline. Paul Rand's 1972 mark for IBM, eight clean horizontal stripes forming the letters, is still taught as a masterclass in reducing a complex company to something instantly legible. Chase Manhattan Bank's geometric octagon in 1961 and Saul Bass's 1974 tulip for United Airlines pushed the same idea further: a logo wasn't decoration anymore, it was a system, built to work across a building, a truck, a piece of stationery, and a television screen alike. This is the era that gave us the corporate identity program as we still practice it.

The Digital Age

As brands moved onto screens, marks had to earn their keep at a different scale entirely. FedEx's 1994 wordmark, with its now famous hidden arrow, proved a logo

could reward a second look. Amazon's 2000 smile and arrow mark carried a message in negative space. More recently, companies like Google in 2015 and Microsoft in 2012 rebuilt their identities specifically to hold up as small app icons and favicons, a constraint no designer a century ago had to think about. The throughline hasn't changed though: a good mark still has to be recognized instantly, trusted immediately, and carried consistently, whether that's on a truck in 1910 or a phone screen today.

Types of Marks

Not every logo is built the same way, and knowing the difference helps once we start sketching yours. Most marks fall into a handful of families.

Wordmark. the company name itself, set in custom or carefully chosen type, with no separate symbol attached. Coca Cola and Google both lead with this.

Lettermark. an abbreviation or set of initials standing in for a longer name. IBM, HBO, and NASA all rely on this to shorten something long into something ownable.

Pictorial Mark. a literal or near literal icon that represents the company. Apple's apple and Target's bullseye are both this.

Abstract Mark. a symbol that doesn't depict a real object but carries meaning through its form. Nike's swoosh and Pepsi's globe are both this, built rather than borrowed from the world.

Combination Mark. a wordmark and a symbol paired together, often built so the two can split apart and be used independently once the brand has earned enough recognition. Lacoste and Burger King both work this way.

Emblem. a wordmark or symbol contained inside a badge, seal, or crest. Starbucks and most universities and sports teams use this family.

We'll figure out together which of these families fits your company, your industry, and how you plan to use the mark day to day.

Building Equity in a Mark

Every time your mark shows up somewhere and gets recognized, it earns a small amount of trust. Do that enough times, without changing the mark out from under people, and that trust compounds into what designers call equity. It's the reason Nike's swoosh has barely changed since 1971, and why Coca Cola's script still traces back to the 1880s. The mark isn't just familiar, it's a stand in for everything the company has already proven to the people who recognize it.

This is why a mark that already carries equity should evolve carefully rather than get reinvented on a whim. Gap learned this the hard way in 2010, when it swapped its long standing blue box logo for a plain Helvetica wordmark. The backlash was immediate, and the company reverted to the original within a week. The lesson wasn't that the new logo was badly designed, it was that the old one had already earned something the new one hadn't, recognition built over decades that can't be replicated overnight.

None of this means a mark can never change. It means change should be earned and deliberate, not reactive. For a brand new company, this isn't a concern yet, there's no equity to protect. But it's worth understanding now, because the mark we build together is meant to be the one you don't feel the need to touch again in a year.

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Challenges Worth Solving For

A strong mark earns that reputation by holding up under real world pressure, not just by looking good on a presentation board. As we move into visual exploration, these are the questions I'll be testing every direction against. It's worth keeping them in the back of your mind too, so we're both judging the work by the same standard.

Does it work in tight spaces. an app icon, a favicon, a shirt cuff, the corner of a business card. If a mark only works at billboard size, it isn't finished yet.

Is it tough to read. a viewer decides what they're looking at in a fraction of a second. If the type or the shape asks for a second look just to be understood, that's a cost, not a feature.

Does it work in black and white. color is often the first thing a client falls for, but a mark still has to survive a single ink stamp, a fax, or a low quality photocopy and remain fully itself.

Does it work combined with other logos. sponsorship walls, co branded packaging, partner decks and press kits. A mark that only works alone is a mark with a limited life.

Is it simple enough. every detail we add is one more thing that can get lost at small size, muddied in reproduction, or simply forgotten. Simplicity isn't the absence of ideas, it's the discipline of choosing the one idea that matters most.

Is it trying to say too much. toughest of all to catch. A logo is not an illustration, it has one job: to be recognized. The more a mark tries to tell a full story or capture every value at once, the harder it becomes to read quickly and remember at all. Save the story for the brand. Let the mark just be the signature.

A Few More Worth Adding to the List

Does it scale in both directions. a mark built only to look good at billboard size can fall apart as a favicon, and the reverse is just as common. Test both ends of that range, not just one.

Does it survive different materials. screen printing, embroidery, engraving, and foil stamping all round off fine detail differently than a screen does. A mark built only for digital use can fall apart the moment it's stitched onto a hat.

Is it distinct enough to defend. beyond looking good, a mark should be different enough from what's already out there to be legally protectable and to avoid getting confused with a competitor down the road.

Will it age well. trends move fast. A mark that leans too hard into what feels current now risks looking dated in a few years, while a mark built on a more lasting idea keeps working long after the trend has passed.

Is it recognizable without its color or its name. many of the strongest brands are known by silhouette alone, no wordmark or exact color required to confirm what it is. That's often the real test of how strong a mark has become.

We won't get every one of these perfect on the first pass, that's exactly what the revision rounds are for. But keeping this list nearby as we move through concepts keeps us both honest about what we're building, and why.

GETTING STARTED

What Happens Next

Here's what to expect as we get underway together.

1. You'll receive the detailed questionnaire. Take your time with it, and add anything it doesn't ask for.

2. We'll schedule time to talk through your answers, your likes and dislikes, and start shaping your blueprint for success.

3. Once your blueprint is set and agreed on, we move into visual exploration, the mood boards, the concepts, the mock ups.

4. At every stage, you'll see the work and weigh in before we move forward.

Thank you again for trusting Adjuis with something this personal to you. I'm looking forward to building this with you.